

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Cut Out the Circus



There was a moment in this year's Oscar telecast which many thought was a snooze. Scott Rudin, giddy with excitement at having won an Oscar for Best Picture for *No Country for Old Men* thanked his partner, John Barlow. "Honey, without you this would be hardware." Now just picture an awards night in Mumbai, one of those where actors perform on stage to their hit songs, and then feign surprise when they win. Imagine such candour about their sexual preferences beamed live to a global audience (although later the squeamish Academy dropped it from the transcript). More than ever this year the 80th Academy Awards were about honouring the movies, no matter the country of their origin, in the most parochial nation in the world. As the film awards season kicks off this summer, there's much Bollywood could learn from them. Hollywood keeps its acrobatics for its summer blockbusters. On Oscar night, it chooses to present to the world a sedate industry, one that means business, that makes art and that celebrates intellect.

Our awards nights are exactly the opposite. Bollywood stars use these nights as rehearsals for their mega concerts which they depart to in droves when the summer peaks. The actors twirl to songs from their own films, or if they don't have enough of a body of work, pluck some actor from the past and massacre his hard work in the name of a tribute. The hosts usually veer between sarcasm at the expense of others or embarrassing gush. Bollywood's creative core, that magical thing that attracts crowds and binds communities, is usually a sidelight. Simply, while Hollywood chooses to appear adult on Oscar day—despite some precariously held together gowns that are only for senior viewing—Bollywood indulges its infantile self during awards season. It's like a frat party where everyone is a clown prince.

What's the solution? Simple. Scrap the multiple awards ceremonies. Media moguls and minor industrialists who wish to share the spotlight with the stars can simply call them to their weddings, birthdays or even naming ceremonies. Television channels which present these film nights can just show us a Shah Rukh Khan blockbuster. As for the talent who get recognition, they can get themselves one homegrown awards ceremony—it will prevent them from hankering after what Daniel Day Lewis called the "handsomest bludgeon in town". And the audience sitting at home? They can just go to the circus.



SAURABH SINGH

GIREESH GV



RED LIGHT:
Stranded trucks

Hitting a Speed Breaker

BANGALORE Nearly five lakh commercial vehicles, mostly trucks, have been off the state highways since February 22 in protest against a February 12 Karnataka High Court order directing the state Government to ensure that all commercial vehicles are fitted with "speed governors"—a speed control device costing around Rs 16,000 each—by June 30, 2008. Truck owners and operators have appealed to the apex court against the state Government notification.

However, taxi and cab operators who had kept their 15,000 vehicles off the roads are now withdrawing from the stir appealing to the state transport commissioner to exempt them under Rule 5 of the Motor Vehicles Act that does not make it mandatory for them to install speed governors in their vehicles. The state Government, now under the governor's rule, has no clue how to tackle the issue even as thousands of trucks from neighbouring Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala and

Maharashtra are stranded across the border.

Karnataka's principal secretary, transport, D. Thangaraj, says the Government is bound by the court order and new vehicles will not be registered unless they install the speed-controlling device. Chief of the truckers' association G.R. Shanmugappa, who called on central transport officials in Delhi on February 25, says the state Government should appeal against the court order and keep the notification in abeyance till the apex court gives its ruling on the contentious issue.

Shanmugappa says it is very difficult even for manufacturers to fit lakhs of speed governors within the June 30 deadline. The strike has affected the movement of essential commodities which are transported in trucks. The ignition key is now with the Supreme Court to devise a way out for the truckers to be back on the roads so that prices of essential commodities do not hit consumers.

by Stephen David